

you can't conspire without someone who is afraid to bet on themselves, who isn't willing to take a big stake on something that very well could fail. Where these two traits overlap there is often a sweet spot: the man or woman who has something to prove *and* something to protect, the strong sense of self-belief coupled with that killer instinct.

It's these two, Mr. A and Charles Harder, one much older than the other, who will do the bulk of the work and both walk this delicate balance of hunger and competence. In the business of bringing down Gawker, Mr. A was the president, Harder was the CEO, and Thiel the majority shareholder who expected his men to mind his money and find the returns he is after. This is the model he likes to operate. Early in the two companies he cofounded, PayPal and Palantir, Thiel would install strong CEOs and leaders. He relies on what might be called the plenipotentiary model—empowering trusted, skilled people on his behalf to execute the bold vision he has created. In Mr. A and Harder, he needed representatives whose judgments were close enough to his own that he could be confident in his ignorance of specific issues and deploy them to the places he couldn't go, trusting them to discern which decisions were important enough to be made by Thiel alone.

For someone who walked away from one of the biggest law firms on the planet, it is with some irony that the conspiracy would create, as his third company, a law firm. But Thiel is a big enough and demanding enough client that within the next six months Harder will leave Wolf Rifkin for his own shingle, Harder Mirell & Abrams LLP. The conspiracy itself is its own kind of company. One made up of three